way, there were huge crowds of cheering people. When we reached the castle, about ten thousand teenagers were gathered outside. After I said a few words, these young people, gathered on a hillside above me, suddenly broke into music: Ten thousand voices sang “The Star-Spangled Banner” in perfect English. They had spent weeks studying and learning our national anthem for my visit. After they were finished, I just stood there, listening to the echo of their voices in my mind. If I had opened my mouth I wouldn’t have been able to say a word.

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I have never regretted not canceling the trip to Bitburg. In the end, I believe my visit to the cemetery and the dramatic and unexpected gesture by two old soldiers from opposing sides of the battlefield helped strengthen our European alliance and heal once and for all many of the lingering wounds of the war.

General Ridgway had volunteered to go with me to Bitburg after the furor had erupted over my plans to visit the cemetery. It was time, said this man who was among the greatest of our warriors, to make peace.